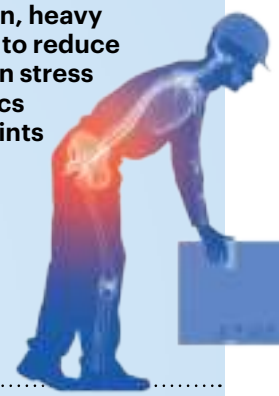
CORE IS YOUR ARMOUR

A strong core stabilises your spine. Include exercises like planks, bridges and swimming to build muscle support without compressing your vertebrae



LIGHTEN THE LOAD

Whether it's a backpack or groceries, carry weight evenly and avoid sudden, heavy lifting to reduce uneven stress on discs and joints



ERGONOMICS EVERYWHERE

Invest in a chair with lumbar support, a desk at the right height and a computer screen at eye level to prevent chronic strain



LISTEN TO THE WHISPERS

Early signs—stiffness, mild discomfort or tingling—are your spine's way of asking for help. Address them quickly to avoid long-term damage



stays, smaller scars and a quicker return to daily life.

The results can be transformative. "The new minimal-access procedures have the same results as traditional surgery but involve much smaller incisions, less tissue injury, less requirement of blood and, most importantly, faster recovery," says Dr Bipin Walia, chairman and head of neurosurgery & neurospine at Max Healthcare, Saket, Delhi. He recalls one striking case: a young girl who was paralysed from the neck down after a sports accident. Within a month of surgery, she was walking again. In three months, she had returned to an active life and even received a sports award from the President.

While surgery is becoming less invasive, an even more futuristic shift is underway—regenerative medicine, which tries to heal damaged discs instead of cutting them out or fusing the spine. Two of the most talked-about approaches are stem cell therapy and platelet-rich plasma (PRP) injections.

Stem cells are special repair cells in the human body that can transform into different types of tissue. A recent multi-centre study published in *Stem Cells Translational Medicine* found that injecting mesenchymal stem cells—sourced from bone marrow and fat—into degenerated spinal discs cut patients' pain scores by up to 70 per cent over two years. Similarly, a meta-analysis in *The Spine Journal* found that PRP—already used to speed up healing in sports injuries—showed promise for easing chronic low back pain.

In India, several private centres are experimenting with these treatments. The NeuroGen Brain & Spine Institute in Mumbai positions itself as a leader in cell therapy for neurological and spinal disorders while Spine Surgery India offers stem cell options at multiple centres. Regen Ortho Sport in Delhi promotes regenerative spine treatments using stem cell concentrates, and hospitals like Tosh Trauma & Orthopaedic in Chennai and StemCellCareIndia in Delhi also advertise stem cell–based interventions for disc degeneration and spinal cord injuries. The costs vary from around Rs 3 lakh to Rs 8 lakh for a treatment cycle. Alongside this, PRP therapy has seen wider clinical use, too. The Delhi Pain Management Centre offers it for slipped discs and chronic back pain, and Max Healthcare promotes it for musculoskeletal and spine-related problems. It is available for Rs 10,000-30,000 per sitting.

That said, doctors urge caution. Both stem cell and PRP therapies are still experimental, and results can differ greatly depending on the patient and the method used. Long-term data is scarce, costs are high and regulation remains patchy, raising concerns about overselling unproven treatments to patients looking to avoid surgery.

TOWARDS HOLISTIC WELLNESS

India is also drawing on traditional strengths. Ayurvedic therapies such as Kati Basti, where warm medicated oil is pooled over the lower back to ease pain and stiffness, and Pizhichil, in which warm herbal oils are rhythmically poured and massaged over the body, remain popular as complementary care. Panchakarma, an Ayurvedic regimen that combines massages, herbal therapies and five core cleansing procedures, is also prescribed for chronic pain, with the aim of reducing systemic inflammation. Yoga, too, is being adapted for spine care: 'digital detox yoga' for tech neck, 'wall rope yoga' for safe spinal traction and Iyengar Yoga therapy using belts, bolsters and props to restore alignment and strength.